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FIRM GRIP ON TIES PM Modi with Indonesian president Prabowo Subianto in New Delhi, Jan. 25

BrahMos—but perhaps not the last. Vietnam is also actively negotiating a deal, and Malaysia too has expressed an interest. All four countries form the rim of the South China Sea, and have maritime disputes with China. This potentially puts the BrahMos, a nimble piece of weaponry that can be fired from submarines, ships, fighter aircraft or ground vehicles, at the core of an emerging Indo-Pacific security regime.

Locked in a boundary dispute with China in the Natuna Sea—the southernmost portion of South China Sea, the main theatre of unrest—Indonesia is stepping up its maritime defence capabilities. The BrahMos, renowned for its exceptional speed, precision and versatility, is therefore a natural attraction. "We have been negotiating with Jakarta for the sale of BrahMos for the last couple of years as its navy requires a missile system. India is also in advanced talks with Vietnam for sale of the BrahMos," says a key defence official.

Indonesia President Prabowo Subianto, who was chief guest at the 2025 Republic Day Parade in New Delhi, came with a strong military delegation. Inter alia, the purchase of BrahMos was a key agenda of the visit. During the delegation's time here, Indonesia's navy chief Admiral Muhammad Ali visited the BrahMos Aerospace facility to take the discussion forward on a deal to procure a shore-based version of the missile as well as a version that can be mounted on warships. However, it is known that some key issues like cost and transfer of technology are delaying the deal. The Indonesian delegation also held talks with the Indian military leadership about broader defence industry collaboration, including shipbuilding and aircraft carrier construction.

India remains one of the world's highest defence spenders, but a need to find markets for the products of its own growing military-industrial complex is an imperative too. As the defence expert explains, its focus is on promoting indigenously developed products to friendly countries, with the government setting a target of achieving $5 billion worth of defence exports by 2025. The BrahMos is a perfect fit here. Since it supports land, sea and air launches, its 290 km range covers more ground than the number itself may suggest.

While enabling Southeast Asian nations to negotiate Beijing's growing assertiveness, India has been mindful of not antagonising China. A 2011 request from Vietnam for the BrahMos was even put on hold so as to not provoke China. The Chinese aggression on the Line of Actual Control (LAC) and the protracted stand-off in Ladakh since 2020 likely prompted Indian policymakers to reassess their stance. While negotiating with Jakarta, India would keep in mind the fact that in January Indonesia also joined the BRICS bloc—of which both India and China are founder countries. Jakarta, doubtless, is equally vigilant. No one would want the complexities of regional rivalry to impinge on this crucial platform of emerging market countries.

Still, what started in 2022 with the Philippines signing a contract to acquire the BrahMos has a momentum of its own too. That $375 million deal, which includes three missile batteries for the Philippine Marine Corps, was a milestone in the archipelago nation's defence modernisation. From their base in Western Luzon, BrahMos missiles are positioned against potential threats, including from the hotly contested Scarborough Shoal, approximately 250 km away, and which is occupied by China.

Vietnam too needs the missiles to enhance its capabilities in the South China Sea, where it has overlapping claims with China. The growing military might of the Philippines, Indonesia and Vietnam through acquisitions like BrahMos signal a united front against China's aggressive territorial claims. ■

WEAPON OF CHOICE

- **Faced with Chinese aggression in the South China Sea, Indonesia, Vietnam and Malaysia are bolstering their militaries**
- **India's supersonic and versatile BrahMos missile is one weapon of choice for these nations**
- **Philippines was the first Southeast Asian nation to acquire the BrahMos missile, in 2024**